

By Priya Sahgal

If the medium is the message, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh could have done no worse than decide to address what is only his third national press conference in the six years as prime minister and first in the last four years. A prime ministerial press conference is an event where the head of a government showcases his achievements, exhibits leadership skills, displays some wit or wisdom and conveys to the world that he is in control. Last week's tete-a-tete with the media in the Capital's Vigyan Bhavan was supposed to be Manmohan's tryst with headlines. In the end, there were no ringing statements, no screaming headlines. After 75 minutes, whatever message he wanted to convey was reduced to a whisper.

Since all official celebrations had been cancelled after the Mangalore air-crash, the prime minister's press conference was supposed to capture the energy and the euphoria of the moment and convey the image of a government that knows its job and is in control. By nature, Manmohan is an introvert, quite uncomfortable in front of the arc lights. His discomfort was compounded by his spin doctors' shoddy strategy. Having distributed copies of his speech in advance, the media was told to take it "as read", which was ridiculous considering that leaders are known to deviate from prepared speeches and play to the galleries. There were also many questions when Manmohan could have seized the headlines—by issuing firm warnings to warring ministers, plugging policy loopholes, announcing economic reforms or social sector initiatives. That the foreign media was not called on to ask questions, except one gentleman whose query hilariously enough related to difficulties in getting a media identity card, ensured that apart from Pakistan, the prime minister's views on the rest of the globe went unsung. It also ensured that the event did not get much coverage beyond India's immediate neigh-

**MANMOHAN FAILS TO
LIVE UP TO HIS TRYST
WITH HEADLINES**

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Prime Time FLOP SHOW

Manmohan Singh's press conference was a classic case of an opportunity lost. He would be well advised to let his work speak for itself.

